

prefer the latter, any day. What's more, there's bad news for all you KDE4 enthusiasts. PCLinuxOS 2009.1 does not ship the latest version of KDE. PCLOS runs on KDE 3.5.10 since the creators still do not have enough faith in the latest version. However, they have promised to make it available on the repos, very soon.

When I clicked on the installation icon on the LiveCD desktop, it was interesting to find a message window asking me to remove a few video drivers from the installation if I do not need them. For example, if you have an ATI card, NVIDIA drivers would be redundant and it's better not to install them in the first place. Removal of unnecessary drivers also gives you a faster booting sequence. Of course, if you are unsure, you can always click on 'Cancel' and move on with the installation process.

PCLOS has a pretty simple drake-live installer that doesn't ask for many options and gets the job of installation done in about 10 minutes flat. However, the partitioning window is not too newbie friendly, especially considering that PCLinuxOS is targeted at people who wish to migrate from other operating systems. Moreover, PCLOS gave me the option of creating a custom partition or installing it on available free space, but there was no option to install it on the complete disk. This just makes one wonder, are the guys at PCLOS trying to tell me that it is always good to have another distro installed in my computer, as a back-up? Don't they have faith in their own offering?

My computer already had openSUSE installed in it and I wanted to use the same 'home' folder. It was great to notice that PCLOS did not offer to format 'home' by default, but only the 'root' drive. After partitioning, the operating system was installed onto my machine and I was presented with the GRUB bootloader settings. While you can always tweak it out, for the benefit of the newbies, you can just keep clicking *Next* till the installer asks you to remove the disk medium and reboot the system.

Oh, I almost forgot, there is also a PCLOS-GNOME version available for GNOME enthusiasts.

Initial impressions

One of the first setbacks I experienced was when I found out that there is no 64-bit edition for PCLinuxOS 2009.1. What's more, booting into the operating system was a rude shock because of the really ugly artwork that they have come up with. Although a customised PCLOS button is always a welcome change from the same old KDE menu button, I only wish they had used a bit more aesthetics while designing it. Moreover, the default theme used by PCLOS will actually make the windows look like that of Windows Vista. Nice try, I'll say. The very first thing I did, after logging in, is change the theme to 'Plastik' to give myself some visual respite.

What also irritates me, at times, is why the distros don't manage to automatically gauge a machine's graphics capability and switch on the 3D graphics automatically? For new users, there is a high probability of them using the same distro for years, without even being aware of its 3D capability,



Figure 1: Revamped KDE splash screen



Figure 2: Default desktop

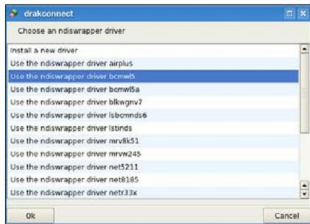


Figure 3: Configuring wireless

ever! At least, a user should be presented the option of enabling 3D graphics right after logging on, for the very first time. Well, speaking of PCLOS, activating Compiz in my machine was a farce since it degraded the performance to a frustrating level. But, then again, I guess this time the fault is at my laptop's end—it's too old.

A deeper look into the distribution

The software manager in PCLOS is pretty confusing, at least for me. Allow me to present my case. Firstly, Synaptic as a package manager, for a RPM distro, hits you right at the middle of the head. What's more, one can't even install an